TOPIC 2 · PERSONALISATION, .RULES AND SKILLS FOR EXCEL
LAB 3 THEME · PERSONALISATION

Lab 3 — Personalise Copilot in Excel for Consistent Service Reports

Maps to	LO2: distinguish account Personalisation, workbook .Rules and reusable Skills; configure, apply and verify each using water-service evidence.
Duration	20 minutes
Tools	Microsoft 365 Copilot in Excel
Mock data	data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx
Course	GenAI for Engineers · v2.4
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-3

Goal

Save personal preferences in Copilot, see Excel use them without being asked, change one for a single prompt, then put your settings back.

What You Will Build

A Preference_Check sheet that follows your saved preferences, and your original settings restored.

Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac. Download this lab folder and open the files straight from its data folder; save any new file in the same folder. All data is fictional.

Data note

Northstar Water Services is a fictional water-pipe maintenance and service company. All service hubs, staff and work orders are synthetic. Use the fixed reporting date 2026-09-30; missing facts remain UNKNOWN. Proposals do not change real assignments. Training email drafts are never sent.

Steps

Step 1. Save four preferences. Open data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx in Excel. In Copilot select Settings (...) > Personalization. Write down your current settings so you can put them back later, then add the four preferences below and select Save.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Money : show S$ with two decimals
Dates : show as DD-MMM-YYYY
Formulas : use structured references
Answers : start with a one-line summary
```

Step 2. See them work. Select New chat, choose Allow editing and send the prompt. Select Done to keep the change, or Undo to reverse it. The date shows as 30-Sep-2026 and the cost as S$35,827.50, although the prompt did not ask for these formats.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Add a sheet named Preference_Check that shows the reporting date from Control!B2, the number
of work orders and the total Cost_SGD, using formulas.
```

Step 3. Change a preference once. Send the prompt and select Done. The cost now shows S$35,827.5000: a prompt can override a preference for one task.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Just for this task, show the total cost on Preference_Check with four decimal places. Keep the same formula.
```

Step 4. Ask what applies where. Choose Chat only and send the prompt.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
In this exercise, which settings belong to my account, which belong to this workbook, and which applied to one prompt only? Answer in three short points.
```

Step 5. Put your settings back. Select Settings (...) > Personalization, restore the settings you wrote down and select Save.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Excel : Copilot > Settings (...) > Personalization
Check : your original settings are back
```

Copy buttons for every prompt: https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-3

Test It

Check	Expected result
Preferences used	Date 30-Sep-2026 and cost S$35,827.50 without asking in the prompt.
One-off change	S$35,827.5000 shown; saved preferences unchanged.
Restored	Your original Personalization settings are back.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot cannot see my file	In Excel, save the file and open Copilot again. In Word, PowerPoint or Outlook, upload the file with + > Upload images and files, and upload it again after you change it.
A number is different from the lab	Clear any slicers or filters, check the table has no extra rows, then ask again in a new chat.
A button or feature is missing	Check you are signed in with your course account and Microsoft 365 is up to date, then tell your trainer.

Challenge

Repeat the task for one different site and explain how the filter scope changes the result. Keep the original verified output.

Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?